

# Dashon D. Howard

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## FOUNDER & PRINCIPAL ENGINEER

Senior engineer with 15+ years building web, mobile, and cloud systems across startups, healthcare, blockchain, and applied AI. I help teams ship LLM-enabled features, retrieval systems, integrations, and modern product infrastructure fast, while keeping delivery grounded in reliability, maintainability, and real-world constraints. Strong across TypeScript/Node, React/Next, .NET/C#, Postgres, AWS/serverless, CI/CD, and hands-on technical leadership.

## CORE SKILLS

LLM Workflows • Agents • RAG / Retrieval Systems • Evals • TypeScript • Node.js • React / Next.js • .NET / C# • PostgreSQL • AWS Lambda / API Gateway / SQS • Docker • Terraform • APIs / Integrations • CI/CD • Fractional Lead Engineering • Product Architecture

## EXPERIENCE

### Founder & Principal Engineer

Semicolon-D | Chicago, IL / Remote

Aug 2024 - Present

- Built and shipped production software for client work and internal products across AI workflows, full-stack web systems, and cloud infrastructure.
- Lead architecture and hands-on execution across LLM-enabled features, including agents, retrieval systems, tool-use, and evaluation patterns.
- Focus on rapid build sprints, fractional lead engineering, and rescue/scale work for teams that need senior technical execution without heavy overhead.
- Current product portfolio includes TravelDay.world and PlayActionStudios.com.

### Senior Lead Software Engineer (Contract)

Confidential AI Startup | Remote

Aug 2024 - Aug 2025

- Built production LLM workflows, including agents, retrieval pipelines, evaluation harnesses, and vendor integrations.
- Improved answer quality and reduced inference cost through prompt and tooling optimization.
- Shipped AI features designed for real-world production use in a fast-moving startup environment.

### Lead Software Engineer

zeNFT, Inc. | Remote

Jan 2022 - Aug 2024

- Architected and shipped a secure NFT marketplace; integrated Seaport and optimized contract interactions to cut on-chain costs by **80%+**.
- Unified data access with GraphQL across MongoDB, PostgreSQL, and SQL Server.
- Hardened CI/CD using Docker and AWS services, including CodePipeline, Lambda, and API Gateway.
- Partnered across product and implementation to align blockchain interactions with user safety and platform requirements.

### Senior Software Engineer (Contract)

Self-Employed / Independent Consultant | Remote

Apr 2019 - Jan 2022

- Delivered 5+ mobile and web applications as a full-stack engineer using React Native, C#/.NET, Node.js/Express, and SQL.
- Integrated AWS services, including Rekognition and Transcribe, plus wearable-device workflows for workplace safety analytics.
- Adopted serverless backends using Lambda and API Gateway for scalable, lower-ops deployments.
- Built reusable scaffolding, CI patterns, and delivery conventions that reduced onboarding time and helped stabilize releases.

### **Senior Developer**

MERGE (Merge Design & Interactive) | Greater Chicago Area

May 2017 - Apr 2019

- Built modular marketing sites and APIs using Handlebars, React, SQL, WordPress, Kentico, Node.js, and ASP.NET.
- Improved initial render performance by approximately **45%** through SEO, caching, CSS/JS hygiene, and front-end optimization.
- Worked across implementation and modular architecture for client-facing digital experiences.

### **Senior Software Engineer**

Orthogonal | Greater Chicago Area

Nov 2013 - May 2017

- Developed medical software applications across .NET, Node.js, PHP, Ruby, Swift, Java, SQL, React, and Angular.
- Built Bluetooth LE mobile applications that captured and displayed data from medical devices.
- Improved web application latency by approximately 50% through performance-focused backend and front-end work.
- Worked in healthcare-oriented environments requiring reliability, system integration, and careful implementation.

### **Software Developer & Trainer**

Virtual Officeware | Remote

Oct 2007 - Nov 2013

- Built an ASP.NET MVC application for automated compatibility testing on Crystal Reports across multiple Centricity EMR versions.
- Developed a system that converted medical intake forms into HTML and CSS, reducing manual effort and improving workflow efficiency.
- Helped reduce support load by approximately 45% through automation and better internal tools.
- Delivered recurring training sessions for healthcare professionals, combining software delivery with end-user enablement.

## **SELECTED PROJECTS**

### **TravelDay.world**

Founder & Lead Engineer | Jan 2025 - Present

- Building a travel platform with personalized trip matching, swipe onboarding, and intelligent map overlays.
- Implemented image-based accommodation matching using CLIP-style visual search to align stays with user preferences.

### **PlayActionStudios.com**

Founder & Lead Engineer | Oct 2025 - Present

- Building a real-time media companion experience for time-synced social commentary across streaming content.
- Defining product architecture and MVP scope for an interactive second-screen platform.

## **EDUCATION**

### **Penn State University**

Information Technology